



SURAJ KUMAR AZAD, 18

OBC RANK 1,676

The family of five stays in a rented house. With no cable connection for his black and white tv, the son of a poorly paid health department employee just needed a second chance to prove his merit. According to Suraj, his mother Rita Devi, who sews clothes to make ends meet, is the driving force behind his success.

country's 15 IITs, besides Banaras Hindu University (IT-BHU), Varanasi, and the Indian School of Mines University (ISMU), Dhanbad. Seventeen-year-old Satish Kumar is another achiever who studied with the intensity of a monk to crack the IIT entrance test. Having lost his father early, Satish saw his mother, Nirmala Devi—who was driven out by her in-laws—shifting to his maternal grandparents' two-room house located in a squalid Patna street where street dogs rifling through pungent rubbish is a common sight. A sewing machine pedestal serves as his study table, while his bookshelf hardly has any books. "But I had sufficient study material. I did not lack anything," Satish says, smilingly. Nirmala's elder daughter has left her infant child, who often cries incessantly, at home to complete her paramedic course. The family has no television and no refrigerator. His locality faces frequent electricity cuts and Satish has often had to

study in the light of a kerosene lamp. "The lamp illuminated only my books, while the rest of the room was dark. I suppose it helped me concentrate on my books," laughs Satish, who got a rank of 912 in the OBC category in his first attempt.

Eighteen-year-old Suraj Kumar Azad is another bright boy who clocked a rank of 1,676 in the OBC category in his second attempt. Son of a lowly paid health department employee, Suraj stays in a two-room rented accommodation at Rs 1,600 a month. This family of five, which lives with a black and white television and no cable connection, has not been able to pay the rent for the last five months. Yet the Azads do not forget to serve sherbet to visitors. A few years back, his mother Rita Devi shouldered all household responsibilities by sewing clothes and selling them in the market when his father turned jobless because of a government redundancy.